‘United don’t seem to want you. Real have said they do. And now you want to play for them. Me and the boys want to be with you. Let’s go.’

It was two in the morning when I rang Tony:

‘Real Madrid.’

It was as simple as that.

Well, simple for me anyway. Victoria and I were leaving the country for Japan on Tuesday evening. Real wanted to have things squared away so that they could focus on winning La Liga. They’d beaten Atlético 4–0 on the Sunday evening and Real Sociedad had lost 3–2 at Celta Vigo. A win at home the following Sunday and they’d be Spanish champions for the 29th time. Tony wanted a deal agreed—a rough outline, at least—before we flew out. It was time for all the speculation to come to an end. Easier said than done. I know how hard my lawyer, Andrew, my accountant, Charles, and Tony, Sam and the rest of the management team at SFX worked over those 48 hours. The people at the Madrid end, too, who also had to come to an agreement with the United board. It helped that signing for Real is pretty simple: every player puts pen to almost the same pieces of paper; you agree the salary and to split new image rights’ deals 50/50. It also helped that they trusted us enough to conduct the negotiations without employing an agent. There are details, though, like there always is and it’s not any easier to reach agreement when there are two different languages involved. Eventually, early on the evening of Tuesday June 17, the transfer fee and my contract had been agreed in principle. Victoria and I were already at the airport, making our way from the lounge to the departure gate, when Tony called:

‘Everything’s fine. I bet there are cameras pointed at you right now, aren’t there?’

There were, as we hurried along the corridor.

‘Well, just be sure you and Victoria realize they’re taking pictures—the first pictures—of you both walking into a new adventure, a new world, together. It’s all agreed. Enjoy yourselves.’

I whispered to Victoria:

‘It’s done.’